grisly summons to the Mughal harem while his body was displayed in Delhi —a gruesome warning to those who would dream of empire.

An enormous amount of Hemu's treasures, which were hidden at Mewat, were now captured by the Mughal forces. His family was also captured and his elderly father was given the chance to convert to Islam and save his life. 'For eighty years I have been worshipping my God according to my religion,' protested the old man gallantly, 'how could I abandon it now?' Maulana Pir Mohammad Sherwani was unmoved and executed the old man and the treasure now fell into Mughal hands. The army marched rapidly from Panipat and Akbar finally entered Delhi for the first time as Padshah of Hindustan in 1556. The populace of Delhi, noblemen and traders, came to offer congratulations to the young Akbar who, meanwhile, had discovered what was to remain one of the enduring passions of his life —the elephants of Hindustan.

If camels were the largest creatures that Akbar had seen in Kabul he was now confronted in Hindustan with an animal that was truly worthy of awe. In trying to ride and subdue 'mast'* elephants, Akbar would challenge not only his own physical courage but also test his immortal self, and would repeatedly conjure up and call upon the blessing of God himself. Scores of curious onlookers as well as petitioners arrived every day to assess this fourteen-year-old Padshah. They watched in wonder as the youth hung on to the swaying animals, his bare feet digging deep into their flesh as he sat on their necks in sweating disarray. One day in Delhi when Akbar was riding a charging elephant his bemused well-wishers ran screaming from its path. However, one small group of observers, Rajputs from a clan in Rajasthan, did not move, preferring death to dishonour, and Akbar was impressed. He was told that they were led by one Raja Bharmal and while Akbar might have been pleased by the resolute courage of these men, history doesn't record Raja Bharmal's opinion of the young Padshah.

In Kabul, meanwhile, Hemu's head hung on the Iron Gate of the city and drums had joyfully heralded the news of Akbar's victory. Hamida Banu Begum, now a widow and queen mother, prepared to make the journey to Hindustan to meet her son, the newly proclaimed Padshah.

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*Persian speaking, from the Persianate empire.

†Fought between the Mughals and Sikandar Shah Sur.